Siddhartha Mukherjee remembers well the thrill of seeing his first cell. It was a Monday morning in 1993. Mukherjee, then a graduate student at Oxford, was inspecting a kidney-shaped T cell under a microscope. "Like eyes looking back at me," he writes in his book. "And then, to my astonishment, the T cell moved—deliberately, purposefully, seeking out an infected cell that it might purge and kill. It was alive." Reading *The Song of the Cell*, Mukherjee's wonder, one finds, is often infectious. He tells persuasively, even entertainingly, the story of 'a life within a life', the unit that forms part of a whole.

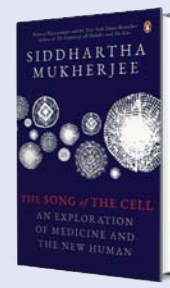
The third part of a quartet, *Song...* shares with Mukherjee's earlier books—*The Emperor of All Maladies* and *The Gene*—both its urgency and encyclopaedic thoroughness, but with this addition, says the author, "I'm sort of ascending the complexities of life's ladder." Mukherjee describes DNA as a "beautiful" and "iconic" molecule, but ultimately, he adds, "it's lifeless without cells". The physician presses on. "To really understand anything about life, you must understand its fundamental unit—the cell." Historically, cell biology has always come up as humble against the more eye-catching biological laws of genetics and evolution, but Mukherjee hopes his latest book might correct that crucial lacuna.

Given the different kinds of cells that Mukherjee inspects—everything from platelets and T cells to neurons and stem cells—his book's polyphonous tone and structure seem more organic than designed. "It was a very difficult book to write," he says. "Everything from immunology to neurology to the workings of the pancreas was being discovered together. One cell theory was established and a thousand flowers bloomed. So, the structure of this book is almost like a series of linked short stories, or a film in which you see the same thing again and again, but from a thousand different angles."



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IN HIS ELEMENT
Siddhartha Mukherjee speaks at The Nearness of You concert in New York



THE SONG OF THE CELL: An Exploration of Medicine and the New Human
by Siddhartha Mukherjee
PENGUIN ALLEN LANE
₹799; 576 pages

Mukherjee, 52, recounts history with a raconteur's flair. There is a palpable anticipation with which we see the cell progress from the 17th century, but it is in Mukherjee's passages about the present—and its many future ramifications—that one finds cause to really get stuck in. Though the term appears repeatedly in the book, the author tells us early on that by 'new human', he does not mean "Keanu Reeves in a black muumuu". Reality, he writes, offers more convincing instances than sci-fi: a boy who has undergone a bone marrow transplant; a type-1 diabetic patient who has been infused with his own stem cells. "There will soon be people walking around with electrodes to stimulate circuits in their brain. There will be people whose organs we are transplanting with cellular therapies. So, I consider these people rebuilt, and there-